

Hunting together

When hunting alone, predators can catch only those animals that they are strong enough to overpower. However, by joining forces with other members of the same species, some animals are able to kill prey many times their own size. Other hunters work together to round up animals on land, or in water, making prey easier to catch. Cooperative hunting has evolved in a wide range of predators, from army ants to humpback whales. Animals that hunt together are often close relatives, and many remain in the same group for the whole of their lives.



Army on the move

Attacked from all sides by army ants, this tiger moth has no chance of escape. Army ants live in giant family groups up to 20 million strong. They swarm across the forest floor, hunting down any small animal that crosses their path.

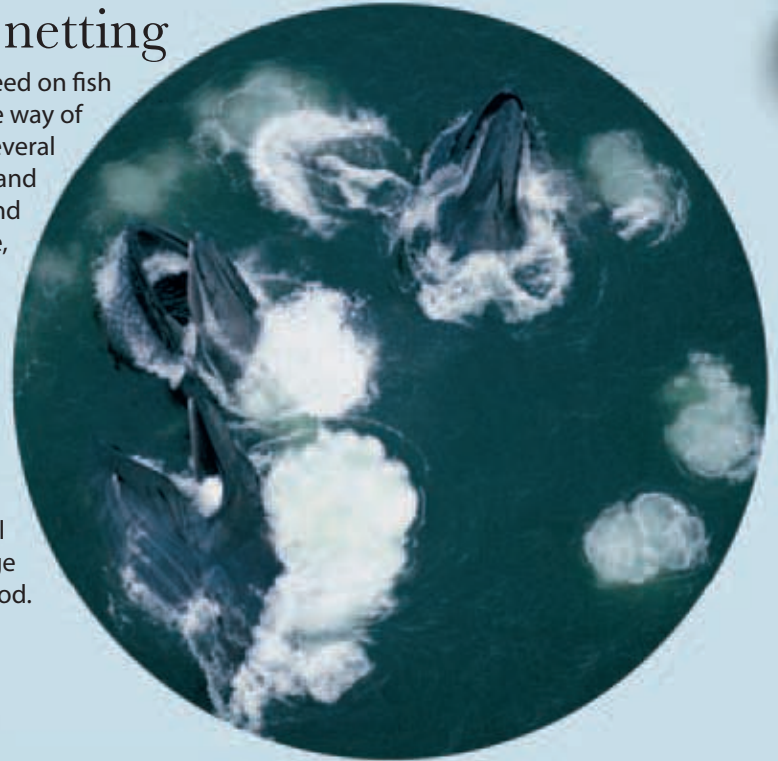


Pelican trap

Pelicans are different from most other water birds in that they fish together in organized flocks. These Australian pelicans have located a shoal of fish and driven them into shallow water by beating the surface with their wings. With the shoal trapped in the shallows, the pelicans jostle for their share of the feast, scooping up fish in their large, pouted beaks.

Bubble netting

Humpback whales feed on fish and krill and have a unique way of rounding up their prey. Several whales will come together and swim in a wide circle around a shoal of fish. One, or more, of the whales blows a wall of bubbles in the water, which confuses the fish and drives them into the center of the trap. Gradually, the whales tighten the net of bubbles, before lunging upward through the shoal and swallowing huge mouthfuls of food.



Pack attack

By working together as a pack, African wild dogs can hunt down a wildebeest that is five times bigger than they are. They chase their prey until it is exhausted and then bring it down with a coordinated attack, which often starts when one dog grabs the wildebeest's hind leg or tail. These dogs are very effective hunters—more than three-quarters of their pack attacks result in a successful kill.

